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Pedestrian crossing warning issued over rule most drivers still get wrong after two years
Many experienced drivers get it wrong despite changes being made back in 2022

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Drivers are being warned they are getting the rules wrong over pedestrian crossings - two years after changes were made. Driving experts say that even experienced drivers do not get it right.

It's all to do with changes made in 2022 over rights for pedestrians at pedestrian crossings. Obviously these have implications for drivers.

The rule says:

when people are crossing or waiting to cross at a junction, other traffic should give way

if people have started crossing and traffic wants to turn into the road, the people crossing have priority and the traffic should give way

people driving, riding a motorcycle or cycling must give way to people on a zebra crossing and people walking and cycling on a parallel crossing

The government's gov.uk website adds: "A parallel crossing is similar to a zebra crossing, but includes a cycle route alongside the black and white stripes."

Insurer LV said that many people are still not aware of what the changes are. They said: "Every now and then the Department of Transport updates the Highway Code. Some of the most recent and biggest changes came into effect in 2022, but lots of us are still unaware of what these are. The 2022 Highway Code updates were divided into rules H1, H2 and H3. The new proposals set to change the 'hierarchy' of road users, giving more priority to pedestrians and making sure drivers are especially cautious."

Others agree. Annie Winterburn of Spot On Driving told followers on TikTok: "Drivers don't know this. Learner drivers are getting confused about this."

She said drivers must wait as the pedestrians "have priority to go first". "If a pedestrian wants to cross a side road, drivers should allow them to cross over the road." However, this isn't the case if they want to cross the main road. "This could be dangerous," said Annie.

The Highway Code has seen changes in 2022 aimed at better protecting pedestrians, with the new rule stating: "At a junction you should give way to pedestrians crossing or waiting to cross a road into which or from which you are turning."

This marks a departure from the old guidance. That only required drivers to yield to pedestrians who had "started crossing and traffic wants to turn into the road".

What does the Highway Code say?

It's all about rule H2. It's a rule for drivers, motorcyclists, horse drawn vehicles, horse riders and cyclists

It states: "At a junction you should give way to pedestrians crossing or waiting to cross a road into which or from which you are turning. You MUST give way to pedestrians on a zebra crossing, and to pedestrians and cyclists on a parallel crossing (see Rule 195).

"Pedestrians have priority when on a zebra crossing, on a parallel crossing or at light controlled crossings when they have a green signal. You should give way to pedestrians waiting to cross a zebra crossing, and to pedestrians and cyclists waiting to cross a parallel crossing.

"Horse riders should also give way to pedestrians on a zebra crossing, and to pedestrians and cyclists on a parallel crossing. Cyclists should give way to pedestrians on shared use cycle tracks and to horse riders on bridleways.

"Only pedestrians may use the pavement. Pedestrians include wheelchair and mobility scooter users." Pedestrians may use any part of the road and use cycle tracks as well as the pavement, unless there are signs prohibiting pedestrians.

Why was the change to the Highway Code made?

The changes were made after a public consultation on a review of The Highway Code to improve road safety for people walking, cycling and riding horses. That went on from July to October 2020.

There were more than 20,000 responses from the public, businesses and other organisations. Most people who responded were in favour of all the changes.

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The changes were made to The Highway Code on Saturday 29 January 2022. They include Rule H2, as well as other rules about roundabouts, overtaking, cycling and the so-called hierarchy of road-users.

The latter is made up of H2, as well as H1 and H3, which cover other aspects of the highway.

Speaking back in June 2022, Trudy Harrison, then of the Department for Transport, told the House of Commons the changes were a good idea.

She said: "The amendments simply reinforce the good behaviours that we would expect every road user to adhere to and drivers should already be following the rules of the road. The changes will lead to improvements in road safety as they encourage more mutual respect and consideration for all road users."

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